

SyncMaster — Founder Case Study

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1. What Is SyncMaster?

SyncMaster is a curated sync licensing platform that connects African composers — initially focused on Nigeria and the Nollywood ecosystem — with global film, TV, advertising, and brand producers who need original music.

The platform solves two problems simultaneously:

- **African composers are professionally invisible.** Technically skilled, but lacking representation, rights documentation, and a pathway to professional licensing deals.
- **Producers are overwhelmed.** They need 5 curated, rights-cleared tracks — not 500 unvetted submissions from a generic directory.

SyncMaster’s core value proposition: **human curation + rights clarity as a first-class feature.**

Every composer is manually vetted. Every brief receives 3–5 curated options. The platform is “Spotify meets A&R portal” — not a generic SaaS marketplace.

2. The Market Problem

Sync licensing — the business of placing music in film, TV, ads, and games — is a multi-billion dollar industry. African music (Afrobeats, Highlife, Afro-soul, Nollywood scores) is in global demand, but the infrastructure connecting African creators to that demand is broken.

Problem	Who It Affects
No professional representation	Lagos/Nairobi composers (Tunde persona)
Rights documentation is fragmented	All African composers

500 unvetted results on open platforms	Nollywood producers (Amara persona)
No one-stop-cleared African content	Global music supervisors (Netflix, Amazon)

Existing platforms (TAXI, DISCO, Musicbed) are Western-built and do not surface African composers or understand regional PRO affiliations (MCSN, SAMRO).

3. The Solution — Curated Concierge Model

SyncMaster operates a **concierge model in Phase 1**: the founder acts as a human matching engine, manually vetting composers and matching them to briefs from producers.

How it works:

1. A producer submits a sync brief (genre, mood, budget, usage rights needed).
2. Admin reviews and activates the brief.
3. Admin invites 3–5 vetted composers via the outreach system.
4. Composers submit up to 3 track URLs + a creative note.
5. Admin curates a shortlist and presents it to the producer.
6. Producer selects a track. Admin logs the placement and commission.

This model generates placement data that will train an eventual AI matching engine. The concierge is the wedge — it validates the thesis before platform sophistication is built.

4. The Product — What Has Been Built

SyncMaster is a fully functional web application built by a solo founder using AI-assisted development (Claude Code as the primary build tool).

Tech Stack

Layer	Technology
Framework	Next.js 16 (App Router)
Language	TypeScript (strict mode)
Styling	Tailwind CSS + shadcn/ui

Database	Supabase (Postgres + RLS)
Auth	Supabase Auth SSR
Email	Resend + React Email
AI	AWS Bedrock (Claude)
Deployment	Vercel
Testing	Playwright (E2E)

Build Phases Completed

Phase A — Foundation ✓

- Supabase schema + Row-Level Security (RLS) policies
- Auth flow: login, signup, middleware guard
- Role-gated dashboard (admin, producer, composer)
- Admin composer vetting: approve / reject

Phase B — Core Product Loop ✓

- Brief creation and management (producer + admin)
- Brief status state machine: `draft` → `active` → `matched` → `closed` → `placed`
- Outreach system: admin invites specific composers to a brief
- Composer submission flow: up to 3 tracks per brief
- Placement logging: fee + commission tracking
- Placements view for all roles
- Playwright E2E test suite across all major flows

Phase C — Schema Extension ✓

- AI-readiness columns added: `ai_score`, `ai_tags`, `ai_match_reason`, `ai_suggested_composers`
- Database migration files and TypeScript types updated

Phase D — AI Layer (In Progress)

- `services/ai.ts` : central AWS Bedrock abstraction
- `agents/brief-analyzer.ts` : auto-tags briefs with genre/mood on activation
- `agents/composer-matcher.ts` : AI-ranked composer suggestions for admin
- AWS IAM credentials configured; Bedrock quotas approved

Phase E — Production Polish (Planned)

- Email notifications on all state transitions
- Loading skeletons, error boundaries, toast feedback
- Mobile responsiveness audit (375px baseline)
- Vercel production deploy

5. Three User Personas

Tunde — The Emerging Composer

Lagos-based film composer. Technically excellent, no publisher or agent. Has never had a sync placement. Knows his rights are not fully documented. SyncMaster is his professional pathway.

Amara — The Nollywood Producer

Producing a mid-budget series. Needs 5 curated, rights-cleared tracks. Has been burned before by uncleared music. Gets 500 results on open platforms and has no time to vet them. SyncMaster gives her a managed service.

James — The Global Music Supervisor

Works with streaming platforms. Needs one-stop clearance + ISRC documentation for African content. Currently has no reliable source. SyncMaster's Phase 3+ roadmap serves him directly.

6. Business Model

Phase	Revenue Model
V1.0 (Now)	

	15–20% commission on placement fee. Manual invoicing.
V2.0	Commission (automated) + Producer subscription tiers
V3.0	Composer premium tier + Supervisor API access fee
V4.0	Publishing admin fee + White-label licensing

90-Day V1.0 Targets:

- 20 vetted composers onboarded
 - 10 real briefs received
 - 3 placements closed
 - 50% producer retention (second brief)
 - Application → vetted in < 5 business days
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7. Roadmap

V2.0 — Self-Serve Marketplace (*6–12 months post-launch*) Composers browse and self-submit to open briefs. DISCO-style producer inbox. Automated commission. African PRO affiliation fields.

V3.0 — Intelligence Layer (*12–24 months*) AI acoustic fingerprinting and auto-tagging. Similarity search. Prompt-based discovery. Composer analytics.

V4.0 — Scale & Ecosystem (*24+ months*) Multi-territory PRO integrations. Publishing administration. In-app escrow. API access for music supervisors. White-label for African record labels.

8. Why This Matters for Nigeria

- Nollywood is the world's second-largest film industry by volume.
- Nigerian music (Afrobeats, Afro-soul) has global commercial traction — but Nigerian composers are not capturing the sync licensing revenue that follows.
- SyncMaster is infrastructure for the Nigerian creative economy: connecting creators to global commercial opportunity through a professional, rights-compliant channel.

- The platform is founder-led, Nigeria-first, and built to scale across sub-Saharan Africa.
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9. Founder Context

- Background in UI/UX design and B2B product management
 - Solo founder directing development through AI-assisted tooling (Claude Code)
 - Comfortable with product architecture, user research, and growth strategy
 - Building at the intersection of creative industry and technology infrastructure
 - Applying to YPB 2026 under the **Entrepreneurship + Creative Industry** track
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10. Competitive Landscape

Platform	Gap SyncMaster Fills
TAXI	No Africa focus; no curated brief matching
DISCO	Western-built; no African PRO support
Musicbed	Prestige curation, no African content
Ordiiio	Closest comp; no Nigeria-first wedge
Afro Soundtrack	Rights registration, no brief marketplace

SyncMaster's defensible position: **curated African composer supply + structured brief demand + rights clarity**. No current platform owns all three for the African market.

11. Key Decisions and Trade-offs Made

1. **Concierge before platform.** Validate the matching thesis manually before automating. Data from placements trains the AI layer.
2. **No open marketplace in V1.** Curation quality is the differentiator. Open browse comes in V2 after supply quality is proven.
3. **AI as admin assistant, not autonomous agent.** AI suggests; admin confirms. Human

judgment protects curation brand.

4. **AWS Bedrock over direct Anthropic SDK** for runtime AI — quota approvals, enterprise reliability.
 5. **Server Actions over API routes** for all mutations — clean architecture, no over-engineering.
 6. **No NestJS or Kubernetes** — over-engineered for a solo founder at this stage.
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This document is a living context source. Updated as the product evolves.